law. By the end of the nineteenth century alumni of the original Dar-ul-Ulum Deoband madrassa had gone on to found more than a dozen allied madrassas in India, and what had begun as a tiny Arabic seminary in Deoband had become a source of Islamic pronouncement to rival that of the ancient Al-Azhar University in Cairo. Today Dar-ul-Ulum Deoband is the headquarters of the pan-Islamic Deobandi movement, with many scores of Deobandi madrassas across the world. By my count there are eight such madrassas in South India: two in or near Hyderabad, two in or near Vellore, and one each in Chennai, Bangalore, Salem and Kollam.

Not all former students of the Madrassa-i-Rahimiya followed the traditionalist path, among them the aristocrat Syed Ahmad Khan, judge, intellectual and social reformer. His extensive contacts with the British as a government official led him to conclude that if the Muslims in India were to preserve their identity they had to learn to compete with the West on equal terms. In 1875 he founded the Mohammedan Anglo-Oriental College at Aligarh in what is now Uttar Pradesh, with the aim of giving potential leaders of the Muslim community an Islamic education that was thoroughly modern and fully integrated with the rest of the community. Osmania University, established in 1918 in Hyderabad, is founded on the same liberal principles, described as ‘seeking to achieve an intellectual synthesis of oriental and occidental learning of the best that has been thought of and said, both in the East and in the West … and the creation of an academic and social environment in which “National Integration” is not a nebulous idea but a tangible reality’. Both universities produce some of India’s top graduates of both sexes – in striking contrast to Dar-ul-Ulum Deoband, where the all-male students still follow an introverted and separatist eighteenth-century Arabic curriculum centred on the Koran and its exegesis.